Judicial Practices and Procedures – Civil Law
Christopher N. Patterson, Chief Judge
Fourteenth Judicial Circuit

(Revised 1/30/26)

INDEX

I.	Communications with the Judicial Office	Pg. 2
II.	Scheduling Procedures	Pg. 3
III.	Remote Appearance	Pg. 6
IV.	Submission of Proposed Orders and Judgments	Pg. 8
V.	Exhibits for In-Person Evidentiary Proceedings	Pg. 8
VI.	Exhibits for Remote Evidentiary Proceedings, Courtesy Copies of Case Law, and Other Documents	Pg. 9
VII.	Emergency and Other Urgent Matters	Pg. 10
VIII.	Pretrial Procedures and Conferences	Pg. 10
IX.	Setting Case for Trial	Pg. 11
X.	Forms	Pg. 11
XI.	Other Division Procedures	Pg. 11

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I. Communications with the Judicial Office

A. Method of Communication

1. All communications to the judicial office must be submitted by e-mail to judicial assistant at williamsa@jud14.flcourts.org. The subject line of any e-mail to the judicial assistant must contain the case name and case number (e.g., Doe v. Doe, 25CA1234).

2. Self-represented litigants and attorneys excused from e-mail service may communicate with the judicial office by telephone call to 850-638-6255. The judicial office does not accept text messages.

B. Ex Parte Communication

1. All communications with the judicial office must comply with Canon 3 of the Code of Judicial Conduct, which prohibits a judge from initiating, permitting, or considering ex parte communications and from considering other communications outside the presence of the parties concerning a pending or impending proceeding, unless authorized by law. All parties must be copied on any e-mail directed to the judicial office, unless an ex parte communication is authorized by law.

C. Unsolicited Communication

1. Parties may only contact the judicial office in accordance with these practices and procedures. Unsolicited communications from non-parties will not be considered by the court.

D. E-Filing Portal Contact Information

1. All attorneys and self-represented litigants must make and receive service by e-mail, which is generally through the Florida Courts E-Filing Portal, unless excused. Fla. R. Gen. Prac. & Jud. Admin. 2.516.

2. All attorneys and self-represented litigants must provide an e-mail address to receive signed orders electronically, unless excused. Fla. R. Gen. Prac. & Jud. Admin. 2.516. It is the responsibility of attorneys and self-represented litigants to update their contact information through the Clerk's office using Form 2.603 any time there is a change in the e-mail account registered for electronic service.

E. Response to Inquiries

1. The judicial assistant is not authorized to provide legal advice.

2. The judicial assistant strives to substantively respond to all inquiries within one business day. If the judicial assistant is unable to substantively respond within one business day, your message will be acknowledged as received with an indication of when to expect a response.

3. When the judicial assistant is out of the office, your message will be acknowledged as received with an indication of when to expect a substantive response and an alternate contact for immediate assistance.

F. Other Communication Procedures

1. Any e-mail sent to or from the judicial office may be a public record subject to disclosure.

II. Scheduling Procedures

A. Court Schedule

1. Trials are scheduled by the Court.

B. Scheduling Hearing

1. It is the responsibility of the attorney or pro se litigant who files any motion to ensure that it is timely scheduled on the Court's calendar and there is sufficient and adequate notice provided to opposing counsel and any other witnesses required for the hearing. Parties should anticipate a delay of at least twenty (20) days between the request for a hearing lasting longer than fifteen (15) minutes and the actual hearing date. Thus, counsel should request appropriate hearing time in advance of the aforementioned deadlines.

2. Hearings must be requested by e-mail to the judicial assistant at *williamsa@jud14.flcourts.org* and copying opposing counsel and any self-represented litigant. Include the following in your request:

    a. Case style;
    b. Case number;
    c. Type of motion to be heard;

d. Amount of time needed;
e. First date movant is available for hearing; and
f. Names of counsel.

3. The judicial assistant will "reply all" to the email with available dates, times, and instructions. Be aware that Washington County is in the central time zone.

4. Do not include the judicial assistant in e-mail chains between counsel/staff relative to dates when each, or the other, are available.

5. The judicial assistant will send an e-mail confirming the date and time of the hearing. Do not file notices of hearing before receiving the confirmation e-mail from the judicial assistant.

6. Email the judicial assistant a copy of all notices for hearing once filed.

7. The Court will generally schedule all hearings requiring more than one hour to be held in person. All other hearings may be scheduled via Zoom upon agreement of all parties. Contact the judicial assistant for Zoom information. Requests for an in-person hearing must be made at the time of coordinating the hearing.

8. Hearing dates will not be provided for motions that have not been filed in the case.

9. Any motions noticed, but not specifically scheduled with, or confirmed by, the judicial assistant, will not be heard.

10. Additional motions cannot be piggybacked on a previously scheduled hearing time without being cleared with the judicial assistant and opposing counsel, and provided sufficient time has been reserved. To add a motion to a previously scheduled hearing, obtain opposing counsel's consent to the addition, then email the judicial assistant about adding the motion to the hearing. The judicial assistant will confirm the addition of the motion to the hearing time. Do not file a notice of the added motion until receipt of the judicial assistant's confirmation.

C. Notice of Hearing

1. A notice of hearing must be filed and served immediately after receiving a confirmation email from the judicial assistant. E-mail

a copy of all notices of hearing to the judicial assistant at williamsa@jud14.flcourts.org.

2. A notice of hearing involving any remote appearance must include the judge's zoom information.

   a. To appear by video: https://zoom.us/j/5750510920, Meeting ID: 575 051 0920
   b. To appear by telephone, dial 1-312-626-6799, and, when prompted, enter Meeting ID: 575 051 0920#

3. All notices of hearing must contain the Americans with Disabilities Act (ADA) notification required by Florida Rule of General Practice and Judicial Administration 2.540. The notification can be found on the 14th Circuit's website at https://jud14.flcourts.org/ada-information.

4. Address: Washington County Courthouse, 1293 Jackson Avenue, Chipley, FL 32428. There is no room number – just list as Circuit Courtroom. If the hearing is being conducted via Zoom include the Zoom instructions in any notices.

D. Submission Deadlines

1. The court must receive all materials for the hearing no later than *three (3)* business days before the hearing.

E. Order of Proceedings

1. Matters will be heard in the order in which they appear on the docket.

2. Matters involving parties represented by counsel will generally be heard before other matters.

3. Matters involving in-custody defendants will generally be heard before other matters.

F. Continuance Procedure

1. Motions for continuance must be submitted at least *three (3) business* days prior to the scheduled court date for which the continuance is sought, barring exigent circumstances. Except for good cause shown, the motion must be signed by the party requesting the continuance, as required by Florida Rule of General Practice and Judicial Administration 2.545(e).

2. Motions for continuance are disfavored and will be granted only upon good cause shown. Successive continuances are highly disfavored. Lack of due diligence is not grounds for granting a continuance. Except for good cause shown, the motion must be signed by the party requesting the continuance, as required by Florida Rule of General Practice and Judicial Administration 2.545(e).

3. Motions for continuance must state with specificity: (1) the basis of the need for the continuance, including when the basis became known to the movant; (2) whether the motion is opposed; (3) the action and specific dates for the action that will enable the movant to be ready, including, but not limited to, confirming the specific date any required participants are available; and (4) the proposed date by which the case will be ready to proceed and whether that date is agreed by all parties. Except for good cause shown, the motion must be signed by the party requesting the continuance, as required by Florida Rule of General Practice and Judicial Administration 2.545(e).

G. Cancelling Hearings

1. Notify the judicial assistant by e-mail of all hearing cancellations and trial settlements as promptly as possible. You must also immediately file and serve a notice of cancellation on opposing counsel and any self-represented litigant.

2. Parties may not cancel a trial without first having filed a Notice of Voluntary Dismissal. An Order of Dismissal must be provided to the Court.

III. Remote Appearance

A. Remote Appearance Procedure

1. The court maintains a hybrid virtual courtroom, allowing parties to appear either in person or remotely, as provided by Florida Rule of General Practice and Judicial Administration 2.530.

2. Requests for an in-person hearing must be made at the time of coordinating the hearing.

3. Any objection to the use of remote appearance must be filed no later than *fourteen (14) days prior to the hearing*.

B. Remote Platform Information

1. The court uses Zoom for remote appearances.

2. Judge Patterson's Zoom Meeting ID: 575 051 0920.

3. To appear by telephone, dial 1-312-626-6799, and, when prompted, enter Meeting ID: 575 051 0920#

C. Requirements

1. Any person appearing remotely must be in a private location that is quiet and free from distractions. Under no circumstances will a participant be permitted to appear remotely from a moving vehicle.

2. Any person appearing remotely must dress and behave professionally in the same manner as if physically present in the courtroom.

3. Any person appearing remotely must enable the person's camera when joining the proceeding and keep the camera turned on until instructed otherwise by the court.

4. Any person appearing remotely must mute the person's microphone when joining the proceeding and keep the microphone muted until instructed otherwise by the court.

5. If a witness appears remotely, the party calling the witness must ensure the witness has a functioning camera and microphone and has tested the internet connection before the hearing. The oath will be administered in accordance with Florida Rule of General Practice and Judicial Administration 2.530.

D. Technology Needs

1. All participants in a remote hearing must have *a stable internet connection and a charged device with video, sound, and microphone capabilities*.

2. Technology specifications may be found at *https://www.jud14.flcourts.org/technology*.

IV. Submission of Proposed Orders and Judgments

A. Format and Submissions Method

1. Judge Patterson accepts proposed orders through the e-filing portal.

2. The proposed order must be submitted through the e-portal, using the "Submit Proposed Order(s) to Judiciary (Court)" option on the e-filing map page.

3. When submitting a proposed order:
   a. Order must be in DJMCA format. E-mail the judicial assistant if instructions are needed regarding DJMCA format and/or attaching exhibits.
   b. Orders must not contain fill-in blanks.
   c. Orders must not contain sections breaks.
   d. Include the following statement in all submitted orders as the last paragraph: "The party who submitted this proposed order to the Court for approval is required to serve a copy of the signed order upon any person(s) not registered to receive service via the e-portal."
   e. Proposed orders not complying with the above will be rejected.
   f. A cover letter in .pdf format must accompany proposed orders.
   g. The proposed order must be submitted in .docx (Word) format.
   h. If you convert a .pdf file to a .docx file, read every character in the proposed order for accuracy before submitting to the Court.

4. Self-represented litigants excused from e-mail service may submit proposed orders to the court by U.S. mail or hand-delivered to the judicial office.

B. Deadline for Submissions

1. Proposed orders must be submitted no later than fourteen (14) days after any hearing.

V. Exhibits for In-Person Evidentiary Proceedings

A. Format and Submission Method

1. Exhibits must be labeled in the following format: *"Petitioner/Plaintiff 1" or "Respondent/Defendant A")*.

2. All attorneys and self-represented litigants must bring sufficient copies of each exhibit for the clerk, the court, and each party to review during the hearing or trial.

VI. Exhibits for Remote Evidentiary Proceedings, Courtesy Copies of Case Law, and Other Documents

A. When Required

1. Courtesy copies of case law must be submitted to the court at least three (3) days prior to any hearing or trial.

2. Do not send courtesy copies of documents that have been filed in the court file.

B. Format and Submission Method

1. Electronic Copy

   a. E-mail the judicial assistant at least three (3) days prior to the hearing to request access to a OneDrive folder for your case and copy any attorneys and/or pro se litigants. Include the following in your e-mail request:

      i. Case Style
      ii. Case Number
      iii. Date of Hearing
      iv. E-mail addresses for all counsel or parties.

   b. You will receive a OneDrive folder, and you may upload any exhibits you plan to present to the folder.

   c. Exhibits must be clearly labeled.

2. Physical Copy

   a. If you do not have access to a computer, mail any exhibits to the party/counsel at the address of record and to Judge Patterson's office at 1293 Jackson Avenue, Chipley, FL 32428, at least seven (7) days prior to the hearing.

   b. Exhibits must be clearly labeled.

VII. Emergency and Other Urgent Matters

A. Requirements

1. If a party believes there is a factual basis for setting an emergency hearing, a detailed motion setting forth the following must be filed: (1) the issues to be resolved, (2) reasons why an emergency hearing is necessary, and (3) the amount of time needed for each party's presentation.

B. Scheduling

1. If the court determines that an emergency exists, a hearing will be scheduled unilaterally by the court. All parties shall make themselves available for the emergency hearing, barring exigent circumstances.

VIII. Pretrial Procedures and Conferences

A. Case Management Conference (CMC)

1. Any party may request a CMC when a case requires.

2. The court strongly encourages the early use of CMCs in more complex cases, multiple-party litigation, or any case that might benefit from court intervention.

3. Unless excused by the court in advance, all CMCs are mandatory for attorneys and self-represented litigants. Parties represented by counsel are not required to appear at a CMC, unless otherwise specified by the Court.

B. Status Conference

1. Any party may request a status conference when a case requires.

C. Requirements

1. Any request for a CMC or status conference must articulate the reasons for the necessity of the conference.

D. Scheduling

1. If the court grants the request for a CMC or status conference, the moving party must schedule the CMC or status conference

pursuant to the procedures noted under the above Scheduling Procedures.

IX. Setting Case for Trial

A. Procedure

1. The Court will set the trial date.

B. Notice Period

1. The court does not set date-certain trials. After the pre-trial conference, the court will assign cases to specific days during the trial period and may assign back-up cases. Attorneys, self-represented litigants, parties, and witnesses are expected to be available during the entire trial period.

X. Forms

A. Access

1. Forms are available for download at https://www.jud14.flcourts.org/forms.

2. Additional forms may be available in the Clerk's office.

B. Usage

1. Forms may be used for all relevant filings.

XI. Other Division Procedures

A. ADA Accommodations

1. If you need an ADA accommodation, please contact the ADA Coordinator at ADARequest@jud14.flcourts.org, 850-767-3550, or by mail to P.O. Box 1089, Panama City, FL 32402.

2. Information on ADA accommodations can be found on the circuit's website at the following link: https://jud14.flcourts.org/ada-information.

B. Interpreter Requests

1. If an interpreter is needed for a hearing or trial, please contact Court Administration at 850-747-5327.

2. Information on interpreters' services can be found on the 14th Circuit's website at https://jud14.flcourts.org/interpreters.

C. Certificate of Good Faith Conferral

1. Before filing any motion, except as noted in Fla. R. Civ. P. 1.202, the moving party shall confer with counsel for the opposing party in a good faith effort to resolve the issues raised by the motion, and the motion shall contain a statement certifying that the moving party has conferred with opposing counsel and that counsel have been unable to agree on the resolution of the motion (the "Certificate").

2. The term "confer" as used herein, means a substantive conversation either in person or by telephone in a good faith effort to resolve the motion without court action and does not envision an exchange of ultimatums by e-mail, fax, or letter. Certification that counsel has attempted to confer with opposing counsel is not sufficient. The court may sua sponte deny motions that fail to include an appropriate and complete certificate under this section.

3. The certificate shall set forth the date of the conference, the names of the participating attorneys, and the specific results achieved. It shall be the responsibility of counsel for the movant to arrange for the conference. Counsel are expected to respond promptly to inquiries and communication from opposing counsel. Repeated failure or refusal of a party or attorney to so confer should be set out with specificity in the certificate.

4. No conference, therefore, no certificate, is required for appropriate ex parte motions, uncontested motions, judgment on the pleadings, summary judgment, or other dispositive motions.

5. A party alleging that a pleading fails to state a cause of action will confer with counsel for the opposing party before moving to dismiss, and, upon request of the other party will stipulate to an order permitting the filing of a curative amended pleading in lieu of filing a motion to dismiss.